

MAN SEARCH FOR MEANING

MAN'S SEARCH FOR MEANING ANSWERS

Question 1

Context of the book Man's Search For Meaning.

This book was written by Viktor E. Frankl who was a Jewish prisoner in the Nazi Concentration camps during the second world war. The book was first published in Germany back in the year 1946 shortly after he was liberated. He was a psychiatrist before he was taken to the concentration camp where he was taken to different camps. Viktor E. Frankl wrote about the experiences that both he and his fellow prisoners underwent in the concentration camps which formed the basis of his book. He therefore wrote about the human search of purpose and meaning in life.

The book is divided into two parts;

1. Experiences in a Concentration Camp.

This is where the author explains all the experiences that he went through in the camp.

- Arrival at the camps in Auschwitz and shock.
- The selection of prisoners where most died by being gassed out.
- The horrible conditions that they all experienced namely; hunger, forced labour, cold, exhaustion, beatings, humiliation, illnesses and constant fear of death.
- His observation of others on how they dealt with the sufferings in the camps and how psychological numbness occurred in phases which are shock, apathy and life after liberation.
- Loss of hope.
- Suicides and constant fear of death.
- Experiences after liberation.

2. Logotherapy in a nutshell.

Logotherapy is a form of psychotherapy developed as a theory.

Victor Frankl says that man's primary motivation in life is the search for meaning.

Ways of meaning being discovered are; creating or doing something valuable, experiencing something or encountering someone and choosing one's attitude towards unavoidable suffering.

In conclusion, a person can endure tremendous suffering if they have a reason or purpose of living.

QUESTION 2

PHILOSOPHICAL ANTHROPOLOGY

HUMAN

PERFECTIONS OF MAN

- **Individuality:**

Definition: self-awareness

Frankl describes how prisoner's inner life was forced to a primitive level and they lost values due to the brutal camp environment.

He explains how a person's unique history and identity were stripped away, and one become literally just a number. The life, name, history of the individual was deemed irrelevant.

Frankl ascertains that individuals can still exercise inner freedom and maintain their dignity in such conditions. He emphasizes that fundamentally, any man can, even under such circumstances, decide what shall become of him-mentally and spiritually.

- **Transcendence:**

Definition: not limited to time and space.

Humans are more than just biological or environmental products. Even under extreme stress, people can maintain inner dignity and freedom of mind.

Frankl outlines self-transcendence as essential to human existence, arguing that individuals can transcend their circumstances and find deeper meaning through spiritual freedom.

- **Spirituality:**

Definition: not tied to matter; immaterial

The true human spirituality acts as a shield against external conditioning. It allows a person to self-distance and achieves self-transcendence.

-Frankl explicitly illustrates human spirituality during an grueling early morning march. Plagued by frozen water-pipes, raw foot sores, and physically abusive guards, his mind completely detaches from his biological misery to commune with his wife.

Soma(body)

- **External senses**

1. Sight: Demonstrated when the train windows reveal the physical structure of Auschwitz- long stretches of several rows of barbed wire fences; watch towers; search lights; and long columns of ragged human figures.

2. Hearing: Experienced through the auditory violence of commands. Frankl describes the rough, shrill tones and the rasping hoarseness of the guards' shouting.
3. Touch: Encountered in the brutal physical conditions, such as the agonizing sensation of standing in the open air, in the chill of late autumn, stark naked, and still wet from the showers or walking on feet raw with edema in tight, shrunken boots.
4. Taste: Evoked weakly through the severe deprivation of the camp, experienced greedily through a five-ounce piece of bread or one ladleful of the watery soup.
5. Smell: Indicated through the visceral descriptions of feces splashing onto new arrivals detailed to clean the latrines and remove sewage.

- **Internal senses**

1. Common sense

Definition: Internal power that synthesizes different external sensations into a single, cohesive perception of material reality.

-When Frankl watches a dead typhus patient being dragged away, his common sense simultaneously fuses his external sight (the corpse staring in through the floor-level window with glazed eyes) with his immediate physical touch (his cold hands grasping a warm bowl of soup), forming a stark, unified contrast of reality.

2. Imagination

Definition: The faculty that constructs, retains and reproduces mental images of objects even when they are physically absent.

-Driven by absolute undernourishment, the prisoners' imagination retreats to a primitive level. Frankl notes that inmates frequently engaged in wish-fulfillment, spending hours detailing food, exchanging recipes, and mapping out imaginary menus for the future. It is also shown when he visualizes his wife's image, hearing her answer and seeing her smile.

3. Memory

Definition: The cognitive power that stores past experiences and recognizes them specifically as belonging to the past.

-Frankl describes how the intensification of inner life allowed prisoners to escape the desolation of the camp by retreating into nostalgic memory.

4. The Estimative / Cogitative sense

Definition: The internal sense that instinctively evaluates external situations as helpful or harmful, triggering reactions like survival drives, fear, or a desire for safety.

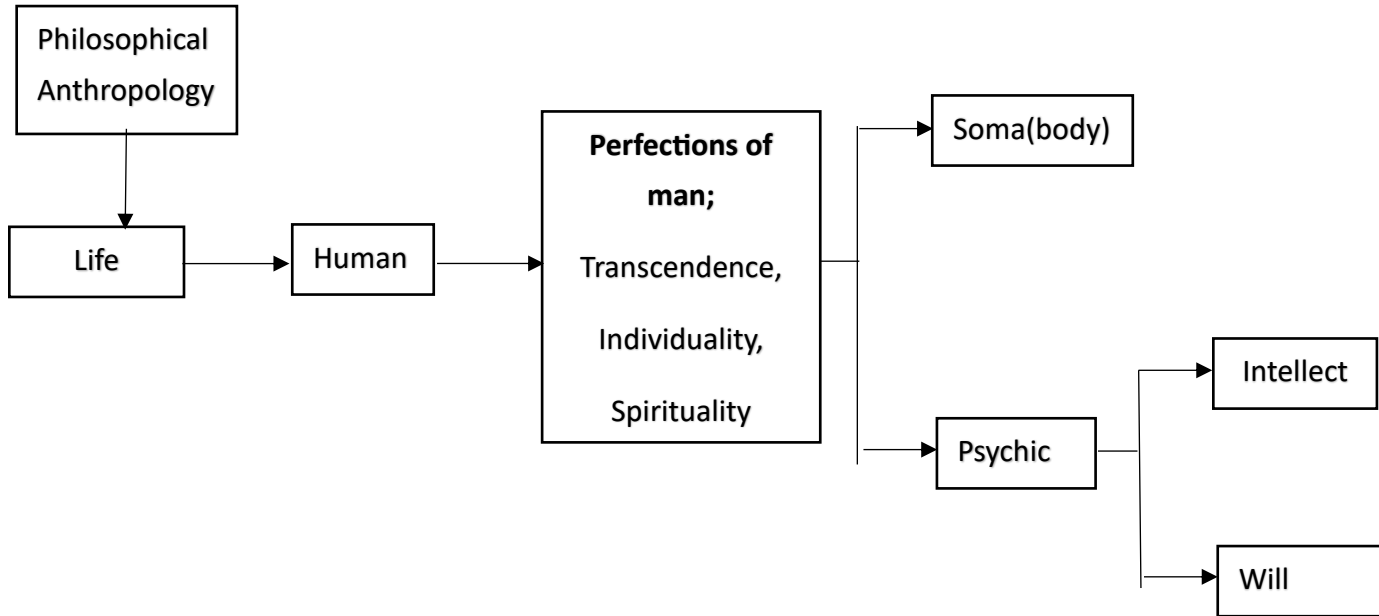
-This power is altered by the second stage of camp life: **apathy**. Frankl explains that prisoners developed an animal-like herd instinct as a direct preservation mechanism. Like a flock of sheep, their estimative power automatically guided them to submerge into the crowd, forcing themselves into the center of marching formations to evade the blows of the guards and seek protection from bitter winds.

Psychic

- Will

Definition The internal human faculty of choice, decision-making, and deliberate action.

-Frankl argues that man is not merely seeking homeostasis but the primary human drive is the realization of a purpose or meaning to life.



QUESTION 3

1. **Love as an anchor for survival** – Love is an intense sentiment but in the book man search for meaning Frankl demonstrates that reason elevates emotion affection into a deliberate cognitive purpose that transcends physical existence. This is proved when Viktor and other prisoners are marching to the work site and the guards are pointing their rifles at them then and his neighbour brings up their wives. Which made him think of her and had an imagined conversation with her. That's when a thought lingered in his mind saying that love is the ultimate and the highest goal to which man can aspire, and that salvation of man is love and in love.
2. **Humour and detachment as defence mechanism** – horror and helplessness can overwhelm the mind hence rational thinking uses humour and detachment as a tool to distance the self from immediate trauma and preserve human dignity. This is illustrated when Viktor Frankl and an inmate friend made a daily pact to invent at least one funny story about life after camp liberation. Harnessed humor as an emotion trick for self-preservation, enabling them to rise above the dehumanizing reality to the camp.
3. **Happiness generated** – This is unexpected feelings to joy, relief amidst horror conditions. The human mind evaluated emotions relatively by rationally comparing present hardships to worse alternative. This is shown when the inmates felt genuine happiness when transferred to a camp without gas chambers or when receiving a bowl of soup with a few extra peas.
4. **Post-liberation sadness-** This is bitterness experienced by prisoners immediately after liberation. A great example of this is when Frankl returned home he found his family dead. He channelled all his grief into the rational task of rewriting his lost manuscript on logotherapy.
5. **Fear of death-** Death, terror and grief is the face of terminal illness or unavoidable death. Frankl recalls a young woman dying in the camp who formed an emotional friendship with a tree visible through her window. She viewed the tree as a symbol of eternal life, transforming her fear of death into serene acceptance and quiet triumph over her circumstances.

QUESTION 4

WHY SHOULD MAN SEARCH FOR MEANING AND HOW DOES THIS CONNECT WITH HOW THE PERSON LIVES THEIR LIFE? (GIVE EXAMPLES FROM THE BOOK)

According to Viktor Frankl in Man's search for meaning, the search for meaning is a primary motivational force in human life what he refers to the "will of meaning". Frankl says that humans are not merely driven by pleasure(Freud) or power (Alder), but by the need to find purpose. Without meaning, a person falls into an "existential vacuum", a state of emptiness that leads to despair, apathy and even death. But when a person discovers meaning, it fundamentally determines how they endure suffering and live with dignity

a) Meaning is the key to survival

In the concentration camps, prisoners who lost their sense of purpose quickly perished. Frankl describes the "muslims" emaciated prisoners who had given up all hope. They were later selected and taken to the gas chambers while the prisoner who had a 'why' to live whether a loved one, a future task or a spiritual belief were more likely to survive the starvation, beatings and disease.

b) Meanings transforms suffering

Frankl says suffering is an avoidable part of life. He quotes "he who has a why to live can bear with almost any how". Meaning does not remove suffering a purpose e.g Frankl chose to view the camp experience as an opportunity to observe human psychology under extreme conditions

c) Without meaning, life deteriorates

Frankl warns that the "existential vacuum – a life devoid of meaning leads to depression, aggression and addiction. In the camps, prisoners who saw no future committed suicide by "running into wire"

How does meaning connect with how a person lives their life?

1. It determines one's attitude

Frankl's quote "the ability to choose one's attitude in a given set of circumstances." Meaning connects to daily living because it empowers a person to decide how they will respond to any situation. In the camps, prisoners could not choose their conditions but they could choose whether to die with dignity or surrender to brutality.

2. It creates future-oriented living

Frankl observed that prisoners who imagined a future task like reuniting with their family were more resilient. Frankl himself survived by mentally reconstructing the manuscript of his book, which had been confiscated and destroyed in Auschwitz, he scribbled key words on tiny scraps of paper, living toward day he could publish his theories

3. It Enables Self-Transcendence

Meaning is always directed outward: toward a cause, a person, or a work greater than oneself. This connection shapes how one lives because it shifts focus from self-pity to responsibility. Frankl describes marching in the freezing dark to a work site, and rather than succumbing to despair, he held an intense inner conversation with his wife. Though he did not know if she was alive, the *love* he felt gave him a reason to endure. He realized that love transcends physical presence and finds its deepest meaning in the spiritual being of the beloved.

QUESTION 5

Definition:

Machiavellianism- The view that politics is amoral and that any means however unscrupulous can justifiably be used in achieving one's own interest.

Sadistic- The tendency to derive pleasure from causing pain, suffering and humiliation to others.

Nihilism: it is a philosophical idea that life has no built in meaning, purpose and moral values.

Machiavellian-sadistic approach to life is using other people as means to one's own interest by exercising power over them, manipulating them and enjoying their suffering.

Positive approach- It is the belief that life has meaning and one can discover and live according to that meaning even in difficult situations.

Analysis:

1.Machiavellian-Sadistic approach

Frankl observed that power without moral responsibility can turn human beings against other human beings. The Capos fared better in camp than in their entire prior lives and were often crueler to prisoners than the SS themselves (Sadist use of power), The foreman with rose cheeks threatens to work Frankl to death and mocks his profession (cruelty) and Dr. J, "The mass murderer of Steinhof," who he genuinely calls him satanic (Machiavellian villain). He, although, complicates it by

showing us not every guard was sadistic and not every prisoner was compassionate.

2.Nihilistic approach

The concentration camp stripped prisoners of almost everything that normally gives life structure: their possessions, freedom, security, family, status and often hope. Some prisoners had experienced upfront lived version of nihilism completely losing their will to live like: The man who started smoking his saved cigarettes and the ones who simply stopped getting up. He therefore argues that the discovery of meaning is connected to ones willing to live.

3. Positive approach

Viktor Frankl himself is an example of a character who had a positive approach toward life. Even though he was imprisoned and subjected to extremely terrible conditions, he continued to search for meaning. He kept on thinking about his wife even though he did not know whether she was alive or dead but his love for her gave his life meaning. He also attempts to help other prisoners psychologically

To help them discover reasons to continue living.

ANSWER:

A Machiavellian-sadistic approach involves manipulating, controlling or using others for personal benefit and in its extreme form involves taking pleasure in their suffering. Viktor Frankl observed this attitude among some camp guards, who he genuinely describes as sadists. They mistreated prisoners and appeared to enjoy their suffering. The conclusion we can draw from this approach is that when power is separated from morals and compassion, it leads to loss of human dignity.

A nihilistic approach involves the belief that life has no meaning or purpose. The conditions of the concentration camps could easily lead the prisoners to lose meaning and hope that their lives are of no value. This is due to them having an attitude because they had no freedom, no possessions, no security and lost loved ones. Viktor Frankl challenges this by showing that meaning can be found even in extremely difficult conditions. A person can find meaning through love, responsibility, work, hope or the attitude they adopt towards suffering.

The positive approach involves recognizing that life has meaning and actively searching for that meaning. Viktor Frankl demonstrates this through his love and affection for his wife, his concern

and desire to help fellow prisoners and his determination to continue living regardless of the circumstances he's facing. He shows that suffering does not necessarily make life meaningless since a person may not always control their circumstances. Rather the way a person responds to unavoidable suffering can itself be meaningful. He also says that people shouldn't always be judged according to a group that they belong to since some guards showed compassion while some prisoners showed cruelty.

Therefore, the book teaches us that human beings have a moral responsibility for how they choose to live and a meaningful life is one which a person moves beyond selfishness and nihilism towards love, compassion, purpose and a positive attitude towards life.

QUESTION 6

Logotherapy is a method less retrospective and less introspective. Logotherapy focuses rather on the future less to say it focusses on the meanings to be fulfilled by the patient in his future. At the same time, it defocuses all the vicious-circle formations and feedback mechanisms which play such a great role in the development of neuroses. Thus, the typical self-centeredness of the neurotic is broken up instead of being continually fostered and reinforced.

People discovering purpose through logotherapy

Logotherapy asserts that life never ceases to hold meaning, regardless of circumstances. Frankl identified three primary pathways to discover purpose and overcome life's challenges:

- **Creative Values:** Fulfilling a task, engaging in work, or creating something of value for the world.
- **Experiential Values:** Encountering truth, beauty, nature, or experiencing a deep loving connection with another person.
- **Attitudinal Values:** Choosing one's attitude toward unavoidable suffering, transforming personal tragedy into a moral victor

To reflect on this statement ~He who has a why to live for can bear with almost any how ~

The why – (The anchor of purpose) - A concrete reason to exist—whether a future goal, a loved one, or an unfulfilled duty—serves as psychological ballast. It converts passive endurance into an active, self-chosen mission.

The How - (The transcendence over circumstances) - The "how" represents physical hardship, grief, or horrific environments. When the intellect holds a clear future-oriented purpose, suffering ceases to feel like meaningless degradation and becomes a challenge to be mastered.

QUESTION SEVEN

MEANING OF LOVE AND WHY A PERSON'S ATTITUDE AND PERSEVERANCE IN LIFE DEPENDS ON WHAT THEY LOVE.

Definition of love.

Love can be explained by the state of becoming fully aware of the very essence of a beloved human being, seeing their essential traits, features and potential and helping their beloved ones actualize their full potential make him or her aware of what he can and should be .

Love is also more than the physical attraction of someone else in the eyes of the beholder or being physically present with them.

Instance of love in the book.

Viktor E. Frankl experienced this while in the concentration camp where he was thinking of his wife when he was carrying out the forced labour in the camp and he had an image of his wife in his mind and said to have heard her voice . He found out that love goes far beyond the physical person of the beloved and finds its deepest meaning in the spiritual. Even though he had no way of knowing whether his wife was alive as there was no outgoing or incoming physical mail it never mattered to him as nothing could cause his love for her to waver or be shaken. The thought of his wife gave him some peace and motivation to persevere the tough life in the concentration camps.

Why a person's attitude and perseverance in life depend on that they love.

Attitude is the way a person chooses to think, feel or to respond to a certain situation.

The author argues that we can have a way of controlling and choosing what attitude to have towards a certain situation.

How attitude depends on what one loves.

Whatever a person loves also directs or guides how they choose to think , feel or respond to a situation like one which is difficult and troublesome. The prisoners who wanted to commit suicide because of the negative attitude they had towards life now had a reason to want to live because of the love they had for the family and work. Love changed their whole attitude of life and giving them meaning to live once more. Therefore , what a person loves can influence how they respond to suffering and how they think and feel about it.

How perseverance depends on what one loves.

Perseverance is the ability to withstand or bear the challenges that one can face in life and working through the sufferings and obstacles.

In the book, Viktor E. Frankl asked two men who wanted to commit suicide and they said that they had nothing more to expect from life. What they did not know is that something was expected from them in the future even if they had nothing more to expect. Truth be told, one had a child whom he adored and was waiting for him in a foreign country and the other man had been a scientist and was writing a series of books which still needed to be finished by him alone as no one else could write them. Hence it was evident that when man loses all hope and determination for pushing on with life after being faced with a ton of suffering and obstacles, whichever person he or she loves or whatever thing they love can give them the will to live and persevere on with life making them find meaning.